Aki Fukai

Principal Product Designer
Design Systems & Complex SaaS

Hamburg · Berlin · Zurich
Remote: US East Coast compatible
Swiss Citizen

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Engagement Model

- **Freelance Principal Product Designer**
- **B2B Retainer Contracts** (3–18 months)

Skills & Methods

- **Design Systems & Design-to-code:** Figma (Variables/Tokens Studio) · MCP server · Component-driven design · DRY · Git workflows · VS Code · Modern HTML/CSS · CSS Transitions
- **Collaborative ideation tools:** Notion · Miro/FigmJam/Tldraw · JIRA/Asana/Linear · Slack · Google Workspace · Relume · Various (AI) prototyping tools
- **Methods:** Shape Up · Jobs-to-be-Done · Service Design · Hypothesis-driven validation · Lean UX · Event storming
- **Work approach:** Cross-functional alignment Fast audit-to-implementation cycles · Adapting to regulatory requirements
- **Regional expertise:** DACH markets · Hamburg-based with extensive German enterprise experience · EU regulations

Languages

German: Mother tongue
English: Advanced proficiency (C1)
French: Intermediate (B1)
Japanese & Zulu: Beginner

Education

HAW Hamburg University of Applied Sciences, Faculty of Design,
Communication design

Freelance Principal Product Designer with >20 years of experience designing scalable software in FinTech, HR Tech, enterprise collaboration, and sustainability. Specialised in transforming complex requirements and regulations into intuitive mobile/web/POS platforms and products through collaborative, hypothesis-driven design.

Expertise: 0→1 platform design leadership · Rapid MVP validation · Regulatory UX · Design systems · Cross-functional alignment

Impact: Multiple successful SaaS launches · Best startup award · Rapid concept-to-market cycles · Enterprise pilot validation

Project Experience 2026–2015

Principal Product Designer, SDGventure

Jul 2024 – Present · Part-time advisory role · Remote
Impact-focused venture building collective.

Hands-on strategic design leadership with Product and Tech Leads for corporate innovation projects. Operating as venture building, SaaS and multi platform expert within Europe's leading sustainable venture ecosystem, collaborating on corporate ventures and spin-offs. **Clients include:** Babymarkt, a PropTech startup, a care platform, 1komma5°, Tagesspiegel Media, Mercedes-Benz.

Reference: *Patrick Koegel, Founder & CPO @ SDGventure*

Principal Product Designer, whatever.works (JobRad Venture)

May 2023 – Jun 2024 · 1 year 2 months · Contract · Remote
HR Tech B2B SaaS platform (corporate venture)

Provided hands-on product design leadership from validation to MVP launch in 70 days, working closely with the Interim CPO and Tech Lead, scaling to 30+ B2B clients. Designed bilingual UX and UI to enable product-market fit on time, winning Best HR Startup 2023.

- **Compliant UX Architecture:** Streamlined user flows for 150+ countries
- **Technical Integration:** Localisation (Lokalise), RBAC, SSO, account customisations, HRIS API integr.
- **Design System:** Scalable architecture enabled rapid feature development and client customisation
- **Team Building:** Hired and onboarded a designer and mentored her toward higher ownership
- **Alignment:** Engaged stakeholders across functions ensuring product and UX strategy buy-in

Reference: *Uwe Michaelis, Founder & Managing Director @ WHATEVER.WORKS*

Principal Product Designer, PlasticPlan (Henkel Venture)

Feb – Jul 2022 · 6 months · Contract · Remote
AI-powered sustainability compliance SaaS for circular economy

Designed the role-based, scalable enterprise system architecture for the processing of high volumes of tax-compliant, AI-driven data and multi-role workflows.

- **Cost Efficiency:** UX/UI design enabled up to 80% AI-driven reduction in plastic tax reporting costs
- **Data Scale:** 236M+ data points processed, 800K+ packaging comp., 160K+ products classified
- **AI-UX Integration:** Turned AI data checks into actionable UI with low cognitive and interaction cost
- **Dashboards:** Role-based dashboards & reporting architecture
- **Bilingual:** Defined coherent UX/UI in German and English down to microcopy
- **Design System:** Scalable component driven UI systems for operational efficiency

Reference: *Dr. Nora Mundschenk, Corporate Director Global Tax @ Henkel*

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Senior Product Designer, enfore AG

Jun 2018 – May 2020 · 1 year 11 months · Hamburg (Hybrid)
Initially Freelance (B2B), later permanent role
ERP and POS SaaS platform for retail, hospitality, beauty and service

Led key UX/UI architecture and design initiatives for the POS and ERP ecosystem serving SMEs. Delivered comprehensive modules end-to-end. EnforePOS is distributed by partners such as Deutsche Telekom, Swisscom and Sevisa.

- Integrated On/Offline Commerce: End-to-end commerce architecture (POS, mobile, web)
- SME-Focused UX: Simplified complex ERP processes for non-technical business users
- Operational Workflows: Developed process maps for fragmented journeys with fast role switches
- KPI Dashboards: Created modular KPI dashboard system for real-time monitoring across locations
- Design System: Scaled architecture for complex multi-device workflows across multiple verticals
- Engineering Partnership: Ensured design QA and performance throughout development cycles

Reference: *Christophe Stoll, Head of Design @ Enfore's internal design studio – small is beautiful*

Co-Founder & Founding Designer, Hello Meet — Group Scheduling

Jan 2018 – Mar 2024 · 6 years 3 months · Hamburg/Remote
Initially part-time, full-time Jun 2020 – Dec 2021
Group scheduling product (mobile app) and social network platform

Co-founded the social scheduling platform challenging traditional group scheduling models. Led the complete product design from early concepts and business model design through multiple product iterations. Development has been stopped for the time being.

- Product Discovery: JTBD-based UX strategy with hypothesis-driven validation cycles
- Product Development: Led end-to-end continuous user-centred feature delivery
- Product Strategy: Pioneered C2B model redefining traditional scheduling workflows
- Cross-Platform Systems: Designed and maintained UI & design systems across iOS, Android, Web

Reference: *Robert Wünsch, Founder & CPTO @ Hello Meet*

Founding Interaction Designer, collectAI (Liquid Labs, Otto Group)

Feb 2016 – Feb 2018 · 1 year 11 months · Hamburg (on-site)
Initially Freelance (B2B), later permanent role
FinTech B2B2C receivables automation SaaS

Led the UX and UI design as the founding product designer to create a customer-centric receivables platform. Designed the multi-party, white-label self-service payment and debt-resolution flows and the AI-driven B2B SaaS receivables management platform.

- Traction: Crafted the product design that scaled receivables management to €25M in 18 months (enterprise clients incl. OTTO, Hanseatic Bank, and eprimo)
- White-Label Concept and CSS Architecture: Highly customizable B2C payment flows
- Payment Journey Optimisation: Self-service flows reducing customer service dependencies
- AI-driven personalised UX: Configurable intelligent communication logic and payment plans
- Regulatory Compliance: Receivables management workflows within strict financial and GDPR rules

Reference: *Michael Backes, Co-Founder & CTO @ collectAI*

Lead Interaction Designer, SBB Swiss Federal Railways (IVEG)

Nov 2015 – Sep 2016 · 11 months · Freelance (B2B contract) · Bern, Switzerland (on-site > hybrid)
Enterprise GIS / Infrastructure SaaS · Public Sector

Digitised vegetation risk assessment for public sector efficiency and sustainability.

- Design System: UI component library aligned with SBB corporate identity across iOS and web
- Enterprise Complexity: Public sector hierarchy alignment through iterative design workshops
- GIS integration: Map-based data capture and infrastructure visualisation enabling workflows from monitoring and assessment to proposing and approving measures
- Mobile-First for Field Work: Designed offline-capable iPad application enabling field workers to capture data in areas with limited connectivity and seamless cloud sync
- Field-to-Office: Mapped complete workflows from field assessment through back-office processing

Reference: *Simon Haesler, Product Owner & GIS Specialist @ SBB CFF FFS*

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Senior Interaction Designer, frog for Siemens/Unify

Sep 2013 – Jan 2014 · Freelance (B2B contract) · Munich (on-site)
Enterprise Communications / Cloud-Based Team Collaboration SaaS

Designed real-time enterprise collaboration experience for "Project Ansible" (productised as Circuit) with frog Munich. Worked in close collaboration with product leads and lead software architects from Siemens/Unify. Ensured cross-platform consistency across mobile, web, and tablet for multi-modal team communication.

Reference: *Justin Maguire III, Executive Creative Director @ frog Munich*

Further Freelance Engagements

PropTech Startup Startup Brand Identity · 2025
Time Management B2B SaaS UX Architecture, Rebranding and Relaunch · 2025
Babymarkt UX Audit · 2022
Tagesspiegel Media Relaunch · 2022
Mercedes-Benz Design System Refactoring · 2022-2023
1komma5° Design System Consulting · 2024
SAP (Fiori) Design System & UX Consulting · 2015
Telefónica o2 Relaunch o2online.de · 2011
CTS Eventim Relaunch eventim.de · 2008
Daimler/Mercedes-Benz Relaunch My Mercedes · 2009
Rossmann Relaunch online shop, corporate site, career portal · 2008-2012